

SESSION 2 — THE MORNING AFTER & THE NIGHT OF LANTERNS

The Lantern-Keeper's plain-words run guide

Read this once before the session. During the session, trust your Run the Night screen — this guide is the *why* behind every button.

PREGAME CHECKLIST (10 minutes, before anyone arrives)

1. Every device does one close-and-reopen of the app (last manual refresh ever).
2. Run the Session 2 SQL paste (adds The Morning After beat + Tarn to your NPCs).
3. Planning mode → tap "**go here**" on *The Morning After*.
4. Spotify: queue "**the lakes (original version)**", single-repeat ON, autoplay OFF, volume test.
5. iPad on 🎧 (ambient). Do NOT show the carnival map until they reach the gate.
6. Skim the PC crib sheet below. That's the whole prep.

THE SHAPE OF THE NIGHT

~CLOCK	SCENE	ONE LINE
0:00	The Morning After	Saltmere wakes to no sea. Billy's reckoning. The town is theirs to explore.
1:15	Dusk — the lanterns	Five paper lanterns, five names in wet ink. The walk across the sand.
1:40	The Gate	The Twins. One honest answer each, out loud.
2:00	The Midway	Games, gossip, Billy's page.
2:20	Grey-Gill's tent	She reads them their own confessions. The heart of the night.
2:40	The Carousel + Whispers in the Dark	The missing note; five private visions.
2:55	THE THREE GATES	The argument. <i>the lakes</i> . The crossing. Level 2. Blackout.

THE ONE PACING RULE: be walking across the sand by ~90 minutes in. If the morning is too fun to leave, it's fine — end the session at the Gate instead (first step through, lights, cut) and slide *the lakes* + Three Gates to open Session 3. The song waits for the argument, wherever it happens.

SCENE 1 — THE MORNING AFTER (Saltmere, daylight)

Read aloud: "*Morning comes grey and wrong. No gull-cries — the gulls stand in silent rows along the rooftops, all facing the sand. Where the sea should sound, there is nothing at all. And Saltmere is out in the*

streets, every soul of it, doing what small towns do with the impossible: sweeping up glass, pouring tea, and arguing about it."

Then, before anything else: **Maddy's breakfast**. She feeds the five for free — "brawl champions eat on the house, loves" — and quietly returns their weapons. (Everyone: open the Bag, re-equip. One tap.) Over breakfast, Griff delivers the morning's weight — see THE TARN THREAD, below. Run it early; it colors everything after.

🦋 THE TARN THREAD — Billy's reckoning (do not skip)

What happened: in last session's brawl, a bottle Billy sent flying shattered across the eyes of **Tarn**, a netmender. The glass took his sight.

Saltmere's custom (Griff explains, gently, over breakfast): no jail, no mob. *"The one who broke it sits with it."* Billy is expected — by the whole town, silently — to walk to Net Row and sit with the man he blinded. What happens there is up to Billy. This is social gravity, not a trial.

The scene at Net Row: Tarn sits bandaged in his doorway, hands still mending a net by feel. He is not angry — which is worse. His son **Pip** (nine, furious, small fists) IS angry. Beats to play: - Tarn: calm, dry, devastatingly kind. *"Sit down, lad. You've the sound of a man rehearsing an apology. Skip to the end of it."* - Restitution is Billy's to invent, not yours to demand. Coins from the Purse, an oath of service, teaching Pip letters, magic lessons — accept anything sincere. The TABLE watching Billy improvise sincerity, mask cracking in public, is the point. (His deepest fear: who stays when the mask drops. Tonight, Saltmere watches the mask drop. Let his friends see.) - **Cure Wounds does not fix this** (let a Druid try!): the cuts close, but a glitter stays in his eyes. The bottle was PRIZE-STALL GLASS — from the carnival crates in the tavern's stock. Court glass. Say only: *"the glitter doesn't come out."* Do not explain. - **THE TWIST — press ☒**
Billy's button after the visit peaks: Tarn leans close and says, quietly: *"I shouldn't say. With my eyes dark, I see better. There's a wheel of light out on the sand. And little paper tags on things — on the kettle, on my boy's laugh. There's one on you, lad. Yours says PENDING."* — the campaign's truth, spoken aloud for the first time, by the man Billy hurt. - **If Billy dodges the visit entirely:** no punishment, just weather — every shopkeeper's eyes slide off him, Maddy calls him "trouble" without the wink, and Pip follows the party all day at a distance, glaring. The town remembers. So will the Court.

Where the thread goes later (for your eyes): the Court can restore Tarn's sight — for a price — and will offer, through the Appraiser, at the worst possible moment, with Billy's guilt as the lever. Meanwhile Tarn's dark-sight makes him Saltmere's one true seer: your clue dispenser for the whole campaign. Billy's accident made the town an oracle. That's the game.

🦋 THE EXPLORATION MENU (let them wander; ~10 min per stop)

Answer "what do we do till dark?" with: *"Saltmere's yours. Where do you go?"* Point at the town map if you generated it. Every stop has a find:

- **The market / notice board:** a fresh notice nobody remembers posting: "FOUND: one tide. Inquire below." (In the same careful hand as the tags.)
- **The lighthouse:** keeper Wick, unslept, shows charts: the horizon is eleven feet closer than his grandfather's charts say. *"The sea didn't go out. It got SMALLER."*
- **Harbormaster's office:** Griff's forty years of tide logs — one page torn out, the week he was eight. He tore it himself, age nine, so he'd stop looking at it. He'll say so if asked straight.
- **The chapel:** the wave-bell rang itself at every tide turn for a century. Silent since the tide left. If Freya Moon (or anyone) touches it: one soft note — the bell is *waiting*, not broken.

- **The chandlery:** owner will sell anything except rope to people who say they're "going out there." *"Rope's for coming BACK, and I'd have to look your mothers in the eye."* (Free line: they can have rope if they promise to come back. Make them say it.)
- **Widow's Walk:** a spyglass on the rail and a cup of tea beside it, still warm, owner nowhere. Through the glass: the carnival, and — DEX or Perception DC 12 — one figure standing motionless at its gate, facing town. It does not move. All day.
- **Net Row:** Tarn's street (see above). A little girl tells anyone who'll listen: *"The tide's not lost. It went to the party. It'll come home when the party's over."* She's right.
- **The salt sheds** → 🦉 **THE SCRATCHER (small event, Peaches's moment):** scratching inside a locked shed. Within: a stranded moon-grey seal-pup — wrong-colored, too long, eyes like tide pools — tangled in netting, terrified. Freeing it takes gentleness (Animal Handling DC 10, or Peaches auto-succeeds — it goes still the moment it sees her). Freed, it hums THREE NOTES of the sea-song — with the hole in it — then flop-runs for the sand toward the carnival lights. **Press ☒ Peaches's button here.**
- **The stranded boats** → 🦀 **SMALL BATTLE A, "The Stranded Things":** by the tide pools, three big pale crabs (SRD **Giant Crab**: AC 15, HP 13, +3, 1d6+1 grapple // **VERIFY**) have cornered a fisher-kid on a hull. They're not evil — they're beached and terrified. Fight them, or herd them (any clever plan + a check, DC 10-12) into the deep pool where they belong. Herding earns the town's awe; the kid names a crab after whoever saved him.
- **The wreck of the Kindly Debt** → 🔪 **SMALL BATTLE B, "The Wreckers":** two inlanders with prybars (SRD **Bandit**: AC 12, HP 11, +3, 1d6+1 // **VERIFY**) are stripping the stranded boats. Talk works (they scare easy); fight is short. Either way they let slip: *"Fella inland pays coin for carnival glass. Old coins. Weird coins."* The Appraiser's already buying salvage. First hint the Court has agents ashore.

🦋 **IF THEY SPLIT UP (solo vignettes — narrate to that player alone, or whisper via Vault)**

- **Peaches alone:** wet, small, bare footprints cross her path on dry cobbles — mid-stride, they stop. The alligator stares at where they end.
- **Billy alone:** a page of blank paper blows against his leg and will not blow away. When he picks it up, faint pencil: a seating chart. One chair circled.
- **Philip alone:** in a shop window's reflection, his reflection walks a half-step behind him. When he stops dead — it takes one more step.
- **Freya alone:** she catches a stranger writing in a small book while watching her. The page (if she takes it — he doesn't resist): a list of names she'd die for, in an unfamiliar hand, with sums next to each. The stranger apologizes politely and is gone when she looks up.
- **Freya Moon alone:** every flower she passes turns its head to face her, like sunflowers. One tucked in a window box is made of pale glass. It is priced: a tiny tag, blank.

SCENE 2 — DUSK: THE LANTERNS (press play on the night)

Read aloud: *"The sun goes down behind the hills, and the carnival lights come UP — and with them, drifting down the streets of Saltmere like they know the way, come five paper lanterns. One finds each of you, wherever you are. Your name is on it. The ink is wet. It tugs, gently, toward the sand — like a dog on a lead."*

Go around the table: **"Why do you follow yours?"** (Their lantern hooks: Peaches's smells of home; Billy's holds an unknown page in his mentor's hand; Philip's is addressed to the man he fears he's stopped being; Freya's bears the names of the people she protects; Freya Moon's made her pendant open one petal.)

Then the walk: harbor stairs, a mile of shining sand, the path of reflected light, stranded starfish, the seal-pup's flipper-tracks alongside them if they freed it. Keep it quiet. Let the table hush itself. 🧸 **NOW upload the carnival map to the stage.** The iPad becoming the carnival as they arrive at the gate is your reveal.

SCENES 3–8 — THE CARNIVAL (your Run the Night screen carries these)

Advance beat by beat with the gold button; every cue below is already ON YOUR SCREEN in the right scene. Quick reminders only:

- **The Gate:** Twins take one honest answer EACH, at the real table, out loud. WRITE THEM DOWN (Notes tab) — they return in Act 3. Buttons: 🔔 toll bell, 🎵 chime.
 - **The Midway:** run a snail derby (🏎️ go-table button). Fire 📧 **Billy: the page.** Sneaking finds the STILL COURT crates — same glass as Tarn's.
 - **Grey-Gill's tent:** the heart. Fire the reading whispers ONE AT A TIME — Peaches, Billy, Philip, Freya, Freya Moon — with a beat of silence after each. Do the bubble-mime when she tries to name the Court. Buttons: all five 📧 readings, 🌊, 💧.
 - **The Carousel:** the song with the hole. Fire 📧 **Peaches: the note is yours** and 📧 **Freya Moon: the pendant stirs.** If anyone hums the note: three seconds of true silence at your table. Count them.
 - **Whispers in the Dark:** lanterns dim; fire ALL FIVE vision whispers, then let the table decide what to share. Button: 💓 heartbeat.
 - **THE THREE GATES:** see the card below. This is the whole night.
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🎵 THE THREE GATES — the ending, step by step

1. Read the gates: green lanterns and moss (the Bog) · silver lanterns and your own face (the Facets) · blue lanterns and stairs into waiting water (the Under-Sea). Hush's slate: **ONE OPENS TONIGHT. THE OTHERS REMEMBER BEING CHOSEN LAST.**
 2. **Start "the lakes" LOW** the moment the arguing begins. Say nothing about it. Let it loop soft under the whole debate.
 3. Let them argue for real — each road pulls at someone's Lost Thing. Do not rescue them from the choice. Someone gets told "we'll come back for yours." That sentence is the campaign.
 4. The moment they commit: **TURN IT UP.** Fire 📧 **ALL: the Feywild notices** (Level 2 blooms on every phone). Read the crossing over the swell if you must. Then not one more word.
 5. Lanterns snuffed. Lights down. The song plays them out. **The music ends the session — not you.**
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🧸 WHO YOU ARE TONIGHT (roleplay crib sheet — posture over accents)

- **Maddy Brine** (tavern): hands on hips, everyone is "love" or "trouble." Feeds people instead of comforting them. Sample: *"Eat. The sea's gone, not the porridge."*
- **Old Griff** (harbormaster): slow, certain, forty years of weather in his voice. Sample: *"Sat here through nine hurricanes. Never once heard it this quiet."* If shown carnival anything: *"The tide got BOUGHT."*
- **Tarn** (netmender, newly blind): calm hands, dry kindness, zero self-pity — which makes the guilt worse. Sample: *"Don't waste both our mornings being sorry at me. Sit. Hold this net."*

- **Pip** (Tarn's boy, 9): all glare, no words — until someone is genuinely kind to his da, then instantly their fiercest ally forever.
- **Wick** (lighthouse): hasn't slept; laughs at wrong moments. *"Eleven feet! You don't LOSE eleven feet of horizon, you MISPLACE it—"*
- **Brother Hush & Sister Hum** (the Twins): Hush never speaks — write his slate lines on scrap paper and HOLD THEM UP (3–5 words, always). Hum answers everything in half-sung fragments that trail off. Sample slate: "ONE ANSWER. TRUE ONES ONLY." Sample Hum: *"...and the tollman keeps what the tollman's told, la-la..."*
- **Grandmother Grey-Gill**: warm gravel, shawl pinned high (gills), knows too much and charges for it in kindnesses. When she tries to say the Court's name: touch your throat, mime bubbles, look afraid. Sample: *"You walked in on borrowed feet, child. Sit. The cards have been asking."*
- **The carousel operator**: hums the broken song, weeps steadily, notices neither. Answers questions mid-hum without stopping.
- **The Appraiser**: ABSENT tonight — that's the scary part. His corner table at the Dry Anchor stays empty; at the carnival there's a small closed tent with a coat on a hook and no one inside. If asked about him, every carnival-folk answers the same four words: *"He's out. Appraising."*

◆ YOUR FIVE (what to know, how to make their night)

- **Peaches capiche** — Aasimar Druid. *Truth*: tail sold in the Under-Sea, "one song, already paid"; the alligator is the only witness and the Court's leverage; she carries the sea's missing note. *Joy*: protecting someone. *Make her night*: the seal-pup, Grey-Gill's recognition, the carousel — and let her mothering matter. *Watch for*: if she sings, the carnival turns to look. All of it.
 - **William "Blue-Chew Billy" Blackwood** — Human Wizard. *Truth*: mentor being un-written page by page; terrified nobody stays when the mask drops. *Tonight IS his arc*: Tarn strips the mask in the morning; the prize-stall page raises the stakes at night. *Make his night*: let sincerity WORK — Tarn's forgiveness, Pip's loyalty, the party seeing him real and staying.
 - **Philip** — Halfling Fighter. *Truth*: trained to kill, chose gentleness; the Court has a file on his convictions; his gate answer is already in it. He was "following someone" — ASK HIS PLAYER who, sometime today, and use the answer forever. *Joy*: protecting. *Make his night*: put someone behind him in the crab scrap; the mirror vignette if he's alone.
 - **Freya** — Fairy Fighter. *Truth*: her vow ("no one I love suffers what I did") reads to the Court as a STANDING OFFER; the Buyer means to accept. *Joy*: making the table laugh — she's the dangerous one who wants the room warm. *Make her night*: let her menace be USEFUL (wreckers fold at one look from her), and land the stranger-with-the-ledger vignette.
 - **Freya Moon** — Fairy Druid. *Truth*: carries the Heartbloom Grove's last blossom; the "blight" was a purchase, filed BELOW beside the Sea's song. *Joy*: casting something spectacular. *Make her night*: the chapel bell, the pendant cues, and one big flashy spell moment nobody asked for.
 - **Table chemistry**: two Fairies = full names on all Court paperwork (running gag, future loophole). The party's healers are the two Druids; the Fighters are the wall; Billy is the voice. Let each be the answer at least once tonight.
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✉ MASTER CUE LIST (chronological — everything you press, in order)

1. Morning, Net Row, after Tarn's twist → ✉ **Billy: Tarn's dark-sight**
2. Salt shed, seal-pup freed → ✉ **Peaches: the shed song**
3. Midway → ✉ **Billy: the page** · 🐼 derby
4. Grey-Gill → ✉ **×5, one at a time** (Peaches, Billy, Philip, Freya, Freya Moon)
5. Carousel → ✉ **Peaches: the note** · ✉ **Freya Moon: the pendant**
6. Whispers in the Dark → ✉ **×5 visions**, then 💕
7. Three Gates, on commitment → 🎵 UP · ✉ **ALL: the Feywild notices** (Level 2)

Sounds, always free: 🔔 🌊 💧 🏹 🍄 — and the Wonder Deck if the table lulls.

Panic lines (same as ever): gold words again → any button → "What do you do?" · "Hold that thought — everyone else, what are you doing?" · draw a wonder. The Book has you. 🏮

◆ *The Song the Sea Forgot · the Lantern-Keeper's Book · Session 2* ◆